otherwise? The question applies to both insights drawn from participant observation and to the M.MAS listening project. There is a grain of truth in this question; I do need to consider carefully whether my presence as a foreigner operates as a confounding variable. Certainly, more times than I can count during conversations in daily life in Yangon, in the M.MAS listening project, and elsewhere in Myanmar, people have made explicit overtures to solidarity with me as an American. For example, "You are an American, you experienced 9/11, so surely you must share my views about Islam", or "You are American? I like America, because it made war on Muslim countries." In other cases, especially with individuals seeking to persuade me, including during some of our M.MAS interviews, there is a clear element of argument selection based on what they assume I would be familiar with or find persuasive as a foreigner. But the point that the remainder of this chapter will make is twofold: that my presence as a potential confounding variable is not sufficient to dismiss the importance of references to a global Islam, and that these references must be considered seriously within any further attempts to make sense of conflict in Myanmar, and for any attempts to support the making of peace.

FROM PARALLELS TO INTERRELATIONSHIPS

By now the parallels between discourses about Islam in Myanmar and those circulating elsewhere, including in the US, should be clear. In both cases, they meet any basic definition of "Islamophobia". This term has been defined in a variety of ways, which Erik Bleich has helpfully synthesised as "indiscriminate negative attitudes or emotions directed at Islam or Muslims" (2011, p. 1585). In this case, what I wish to emphasize is that the narratives in Myanmar and elsewhere treat Islam as homogenous, without distinguishing between diverse religious traditions; that they are applied to both Islam as a religion and to Muslims as followers of Islam; and that they are intensely negative. This is not to advocate that Islamophobia per se is a particularly useful lens for understanding communal conflict in Myanmar — I will return to this point in the conclusion. Instead, employing Bleich's definition highlights the fact that narratives about Islam in Myanmar, the US, and elsewhere meet his definition and, in doing so, have broad shapes and content that are consistent with one another.

The narratives treat Islam similarly, as unitary and Muslims as